HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

When Humility Isn't Required: The Limits of Anavah

Given Monday 18 May 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem, Chapter 7 Part 5

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Kifayat al-Abidin) — Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam **Chapter:** Perek 7 (ענוה — Humility) — **Part 5 (concluding the chapter) Edition:** Feldheim **This week:** Limits of humility · Humility between people · When leaders must suspend external humility · Praise of the humble

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Recap: The Full Chapter So Far

Definition (Part 1)

- Humility = recognizing one's true status without exaggeration in either direction
- Internal and external humility; humility before Hashem and before people
- **Humility ≠ self-debasement** — this will become critical tonight

The Three Methods of Training

1. **Practical/experiential** — company, exterior conduct, possessions
2. **Through the Torah** — stories (Tanakh figures who lived or failed humility) + mitzvot (12+ specific mitzvot designed to instill anavah)
3. **Intellectual / philosophical analysis** *(Parts 3 & 4)*

The Intellectual Analysis (Parts 3 & 4)

- **Physical things** — identical to animals; their excess causes illness
- **Material/positional things** — generate strife; kings die violently and prematurely
- **Spiritual/intellectual things** — fragile (lost through hunger, fatigue); the higher you reach, the more you see how much is above you
- **Cosmic comparison** — if you compare downward, you must compare upward too (celestial bodies, angels, Hashem)
- **Religious arrogance** — most dangerous form; the Rambam's "teshuva for having nothing to do teshuva for"
- **Critical caveat:** the analysis is a counterweight to pride, NOT a tool for self-loathing

Last Week's Final Section

- **Humility before Hashem** — universal obligation (all creatures with intellect)
- The five bowings in Amidah (don't miss the fifth — at the three steps back)
- The King had to be bowed throughout the entire Amidah (Shlomo as the model)

Tonight's Roadmap

1. **The limits of humility** — distinguishing anavah from shiflut (lowliness)
2. **Humility between people** — practical conduct
3. **Leaders: when external humility must be suspended**
4. **Praise of the humble** — concluding the chapter

PART 1 — The Limits of Humility: Anavah vs. Shiflut

Rabbi Avraham makes a critical distinction before going further. **External humility is real and obligatory — but it must not degrade into self-debasement.**

והוא שעליך להבדיל בין ענווה חיצונית המחויבת ובין השפלות והבזיון שהם מדות נתעבות

You must distinguish between obligatory external humility and lowliness/degradation, which are abominable traits.

The Principle on Clothing

על אף שהענווה החיצונית מחייבת ללבוש בגדים גסים, אין מחובת הענו ללבוש בגדים מטונפים ומגואלים

External humility requires simple clothes — NOT dirty or stained clothes.

The psychological/spiritual logic is real:

- A person who presents respectfully on the outside maintains internal respect
- A person who walks in disrespectful, unkempt clothing damages their own inner sense of self
- The exterior reflects — and reinforces — the interior

The Story of Rav Shlomo Zalman Auerbach

A father came to visit his son at Yeshiva. The son wasn't in his room. The father saw the room — clean, tidy, neat — left a note, and went home.

When asked why he didn't go to the Beit Midrash to see his son, he answered: *"I went to his bedroom. I saw everything clean and tidy. I know he's doing well and learning well. I can go home now."*

The clean, ordered exterior tells the truth about the inner life.

The Talmid Chacham and Stained Clothes

The Gemara learns from a verse in Mishlei:

כל משנאי אהבו מות — אל תקרא משנאי אלא משניאי

"All who hate Me love death" — do not read 'hate Me' but 'cause others to hate Me'."

A Talmid Chacham with stained clothes who functions as a public role model **causes others to hate Torah** — because he reflects badly on what he represents. The Gemara goes so far as to say he is *chayav mitah*.

The Standard for Clothing and Home

אלא שיהיה לבוש תלמיד חכם לבן ונקי

The Talmid Chacham's clothing should be **clean** — Rabbi Avraham adds the word *lavan* (white).

What Does Lavan Mean Here?

Interpretation	Source
Meluban — cleansed, freshly laundered	The commentators on Rabbi Avraham
Literally white — invoking purity	Rabbi Avraham's great-grandson Rabbeinu David

Either way, the **core point is clean and presentable**, not extravagant.

The Full Standard

- Even simple cotton clothes (thin in summer, thick in winter — no need for silk or expensive materials)
- **Must not be stained with oil or grease**
- **Shoes must not be covered in dirt and mud**
- They should protect the feet from filth — i.e., be functional and clean
- **The home, even without marble floors, must be swept and washed**
- **Rugs, even of simple reed material, must not be filthy**

מכאן אפשר ללמוד לכל שאר הדברים כי הצמצום וחוסר התפנוקים מחזקים את הענווה. ואילו הלכלוך והטינופת אינם אלא זלזול וטומאה

Extrapolate to everything: minimalism and lack of luxury strengthen humility. But filth and dirt are mere disrespect and impurity.

The Practical Principle

Anavah	Shiflut (Wrong)
Simple clothes	Dirty clothes
Modest home	Filthy home
Functional shoes	Mud-caked shoes
Plain rugs	Stained rugs
Recognized one's place	Debased oneself

PART 2 — Humility Between People (Practical Conduct)

Now Rabbi Avraham turns to **how humility is practiced in interactions with other human beings.**

Conduct 1 — Pleasantness and Greeting

שלא יתגאה בן אדם ולא יראהו סר וזעף אלא רך הליכות... הוי מקבל את כל האדם בסבר פנים יפות

Don't appear haughty, angry, or sullen. Be gentle in manner. Greet everyone with a pleasant face.

Two Specific Practices

1. Always be the first to greet

מימי לא הקדמני אדם לשלום אפילו גוי

The Chacham (likely Rav in Berachot) said: *"No one ever greeted me first — even a non-Jew."*

The point: don't wait for others to acknowledge you. Acknowledge them first. The wait-to-be-greeted mentality is the mentality of arrogance.

2. Respond fully when greeted

It's not enough to say "shalom" back. *"V'yachzir lahem shalom"* means returning the greeting **with continuation** — not just a curt "hi" but engaging the conversation.

The Boaz Model

When Boaz came to his harvesters in the field:

"Hashem be with you" — ה' עמכם — *"And they answered: Hashem bless you"* — ויענו לו: יברכך ה'

A complete two-way greeting — Boaz greeted first, they responded fully. This is the model.

(Some Sefardim follow this when called to the Torah: *"Hashem imachem"* and the community responds *"Yevarechecha Hashem"*.)

Conduct 2 — Don't Seek Prominent Seats

בשעת נוכחותו בעצרותיהם... לא יהא להוט אחר מקומות הגבוהים

Whether at a mitzvah gathering or a social one — don't pursue the prominent seats.

Shlomo's Verse

כי טוב אמור לך עלה הנה מהשפילך לפני נדיב אשר ראו עיניך

"Better to be told 'come up here' than to be lowered before the prince whom your eyes have seen."

The painful experience the verse warns about: you go to the front, you can't find your seat there, you sit somewhere reserved — and you're publicly told to move back. **Far better** to take a back seat and, if your importance warrants it, be invited forward.

The Logic

- This is not about thinking lowly of yourself
- It's about knowing your place — and trusting that if you have underestimated yourself, the natural movement of events will bring you forward
- The chase for prominence reveals insecurity, not value

Conduct 3 — Tolerating Difficult People

ועליו לנהוג באדיבות עם הבריות כמידת יכולתו

Act with adivut (calmness/grace/tact) toward people as much as you can.

When Someone Is Coarse or Insulting

Rabbi Avraham's reframe is striking:

עליו להעביר על מידותיו ולהצטער על אותו אדם

Pass over his own dignity — and feel sorry for that person.

When someone speaks roughly to you, the response is not anger, not retaliation, not grudge — but **pity for the person who must speak that way**.

The Five Negative Mitzvot at Stake

Don't let the yetzer hara drive you to:

כדי שלא יעבור על חמישה לא תעשה שבפניהם

	Mitzvah
1	לא תקום — Don't take revenge
2	לא תטור — Don't bear a grudge
3	לא תשנא את אחיך בלבבך — Don't hate your brother in your heart
4	ואהבת לרעך כמוך — Love your neighbor as yourself (as a positive companion)
5	(Various related prohibitions on hostile speech)

The Critical Boundary — Don't Become Anyone's Servant

This is where the chapter's anti-shiflut theme returns:

אין צריך אף לא נאה אף אסור שיאדם בעל אופי קל דעת... מן השקט עם עם הארץ ונותן לו קדימה ומשרתו תמיד בלי צורך דתי או חומרי

It is not necessary, not appropriate, and even forbidden to act in a foolish manner — to be one who, for example:

- Kisses the hand of an ordinary, ignorant person
- Always gives precedence to common folk

- Constantly serves them with no religious or practical reason

שאין ענווה אלא ביזיון והשפלה מראים החיסרון דעת ושכל

This is not humility — it is degradation and lowliness, revealing lack of intelligence and discernment, not good character or religious devotion.

The Distinction

Legitimate (Anavah)	Illegitimate (Shiflut)
Hakarat hatov to someone who helped you	Subservience to ordinary people for no reason
Honoring a Chacham to learn from him	Kissing the hand of the ammei ha'aretz
Serving a parent, mentor, or rabbi	Being everyone's servant
Respecting a person's authentic position	Performance of self-degradation

Why It's Forbidden

The people one might falsely "honor" in this way — when they are described:

מרבים שיחה בטבע האכילה והשתייה וכיוצא באלה

These are people who waste time on food and drink and trivialities. Honoring them with submission is not anavah — it endorses what is corrupt.

פן תטעה ותחשוב על אחד מהדברים שהזהרנו עליהם שהיא ענווה דגולה ובאמת אינו אלא השפלת המידות ופסול דתי ורגש מגונה

Beware of confusing what you think is humility with what is actually a corruption of character.

PART 3 — Leaders: When External Humility Must Be Suspended

This is the heart of the chapter's practical sophistication. **For most people, external humility is constant. For leaders, the situation is different.**

אבל מי שעליו מוטלת האחריות להנהגת אחרים הרי הוא מאחד משני סוגים

If responsibility for leading others is on you, you are one of two kinds:

Type 1 — Leader of a Spiritual Group

A leader of a select group on a spiritual journey:

- Less common today, more common in Rabbi Avraham's time
- Examples: Chasidic groups, schools of prophets

The Rule for Type 1

חובה עליהם להחזיק בענווה החיצונית והפנימית

Such a leader must maintain both internal AND external humility.

Why? Because the leader is the model. The students see how he walks the path. If he abandons external humility, the lesson is broken.

The Examples

- **Elisha** went with the Bnei HaNeviim to cut wood. He didn't say "I'm the prophet, you do the work." He worked alongside them.
- **Shmuel** stood with the schools of the prophets — present in their training, not aloof.

The lesson: spiritual leadership requires walking among the disciples.

Type 2 — Public Leader of Diverse Masses

A leader of many different kinds of people — with varying aspirations and views:

- King of Israel
- Rosh Galut (Exilarch)
- Rosh Yeshiva or chief rabbi
- Shoftim (judges) and the officers of the community
- Anyone whose role is to enforce, judge, guide, and command

The Rule for Type 2

מחייבהו הצורך המפורש בתורה... שום תשים עליך מלך — שתהא אימתו עליך

The Torah commands: *"You shall surely place a king over you"* — and the Gemara extends this to mean **"that his awe should be upon you."**

For the leader's authority to function, the people must have reverence/awe for him. This requires the leader to **present externally with the bearing of authority**, not with the demonstrative humility of a Type 1 leader.

וזוהי סטייה מן הענווה החיצונית

This is a departure from external humility.

The Critical Caveat

אבל סטייה נובעת מנחיצות, ורק בתנאי שתשמר הענווה הפנימית

It is a departure required by necessity — and only on the condition that internal humility is preserved.

The Torah's warning to the king: **לבלתי רום לבבו מאחיו** — *"that his heart not be lifted above his brothers."* Even with all the external pomp, the internal must remain humble.

David HaMelech and Michal

When David danced before the Aron and was rebuked by Michal:

- David: *"I will be even more lowly than this and humble in my own eyes"* (internal humility preserved)
- David: *"And with the maidservants you mentioned, I will be honored by them"*

Why the Second Statement?

If David is truly humble, why does he care about the maidservants' opinion?

Answer (Rabbi Avraham): Because David is the king. The maidservants — and through them, the community — must **respect** the king for his authority to function. So David is not seeking personal glory; he is **preserving the legitimacy of his role** by ensuring the community treats him with the honor his position requires.

ועם זאת אין צריך אף לא נאה ולא יאדם בעל אופי קל דעת

External honor for a leader is required — but internal arrogance is forbidden.

Practical Halacha — The King's Conduct

Public Behavior

כיוון שנתמנה אדם פרנס לציבור אסור לעשות מלאכה בפני שלושה

Once a person is appointed a public leader, he may not perform menial work in front of three people.

- If only 1-2 people are present → fine
- If 3+ are present → forbidden (it undermines the authority needed for the role)

Practical examples for a public figure:

- Don't fix the toilet when guests are at home
- Don't repair the tap when others see you
- Don't perform menial labor publicly

Honoring Chachamim

The Rambam in Hilchot Melachim:

- It is a mitzvah for everyone to honor the king
- The king must honor Chachamim — when the Sanhedrin enters, he stands
- **BUT only in private.** In a public setting, the king does NOT stand for the head of the Sanhedrin.

Why? Because in public, the king's authority must be preserved. If people see the king standing for the Rosh Sanhedrin, the king's authority erodes.

Yehoshafat's Model

When Yehoshafat King of Judah was alone with a Talmid Chacham:

- He would **rise from his throne**
- **Embrace and kiss** the Chacham
- Call him **"Rabbi and my master"**

But in public:

- He addressed the same Chacham by name
- Maintained his royal bearing

- Did not display the same demonstrative humility

This is the model: **private humility, public authority.**

How to Preserve Internal Humility Despite External Authority

This is the most dangerous balance — and Rabbi Avraham gives a practical regimen:

ולכן המחפש דרך ה' צריך שירחיק מן השררה והשלטון

Therefore, one seeking the path of Hashem should avoid positions of leadership unless they are necessary for the benefit of others.

The Mishna in Pirkei Avot: **שנא את הרבנות** — *"hate positions of authority."* Because the tightrope is so difficult.

If You Must Lead — The Anti-Arrogance Regimen

ישמור לבו וגאוותו שכבר נתנו לו סממנים על ידי תפילות ותחנונים, וקימה בלילות וריבוי כריעות והשתחויות

Practice	Purpose
Extra prayer and supplication	Counterweight against internal pride
Waking at night to pray	Pre-dawn humility before dawn's public role
Many bowings and prostrations	Physical reminder of lowliness before Hashem
Studying the prophets' humility	Internalizing the model
Reviewing the intellectual analysis of last week	Re-grounding the philosophical case
Spending time with God-fearing people	Subduing oneself in their presence
Hachna'ah chitzonit (external submission) before them in private	Feeling the proper hierarchy

David's Practice

חצות לילה אקום להודות לך — *"At midnight I rise to praise You"* חבר אני לכל אשר יראוך — *"I am a companion to all who fear You"* בחנני ה' ונסני, צרפה כליותי ולבי — *"Test me, Hashem, examine my innermost being"*

David HaMelech's regimen: night-time prayer, association with the God-fearing, willingness to be examined — all to preserve internal humility while bearing the external weight of kingship.

A Modern Application — Parents and Children

A practical example raised in the shiur:

Should children call their parents by their first names?

Approach	Assessment
Traditional (Abba/Imma, Mommy/Daddy)	Maintains the eimah and proper hierarchical relationship
Children call parents by first names	**Generally inappropriate** — even in loving relationships, removes the necessary respect for parental authority
Cultural variation (some American families)	Halachically debatable — may be implied consent (parent is *mochel al kevodo*), but the structural concern remains

The Halachic Source

- Honoring parents (and rabbis) is a mitzvah
- The standard is not to call them by first name unless they consent
- A rav or parent **can** be mochel al kevodo (forgo their honor)
- Implied cultural consent might cover the family that's used to it
- But the underlying principle: **authority requires respect — even within love.** A parent who loses their authority loses their effective role.

The Broader Principle Beyond Religious Leadership

The principle applies to **any position of legitimate authority**:

- Parent → child
- Teacher → student
- Manager/CEO → employees
- Rabbi → community
- Judge → litigants

In each case:

1. **External**: bearing of authority required for the role to function
2. **Internal**: constant humility, prayer, self-examination
3. **In private**: deference to those who deserve it (a CEO to his board, a rabbi to his rebbeim)

The Risk Curve

Position	Internal Risk
Following	Easy to be humble
Leading a small group	Moderate risk
Leading the masses	**Maximum risk**
The king	**Highest risk** — therefore the most intensive antidote (the king's Sefer Torah, total prostration in prayer, etc.)

This is consistent with what we saw earlier in the chapter — those at risk of the worst arrogance are given the most intensive humility-training mitzvot.

PART 4 — Praise of the Humble

The chapter concludes with biblical praise for the humble.

What the Humble Receive

1. Hashgachah (Divine Providence)

השגחת השכינה שורה עליהם

The Shechinah dwells upon the humble. They are protected and watched over.

2. Emotional Stability

בזכות חירותם מגאוה אינם מתפעלים, ואינם מתרגזים משלטונם של עושי עול

- They are not easily moved or shaken emotionally
- They don't quickly become upset by the behavior of the wicked
- Arrogant people are emotionally fragile — easily disturbed; humble people have steadiness

David: > אל תבואני רגל גאוה ויד רשעים אל תנדני *"Let not the foot of pride come upon me, and let not the hand of the wicked move me"*

The connection: **if I'm not arrogant, I cannot be moved by the wicked.** Arrogance is what makes us vulnerable to others' provocations.

3. Their Prayers Are Heard

תאות ענוים שמעת ה', תכין לבם תקשיב אזנך *"You hear the desire of the humble, Hashem — You direct their heart, You incline Your ear"*

Because the prayers of the humble come from a pure heart, Hashem accepts them and fulfills their needs.

4. They Are First to See Salvation

יפאר ענוים בישועה *"He glorifies the humble with salvation"*

בונה ירושלים ה' נדחי ישראל יכנס, הרופא לשבורי לב ומחבש לעצבותם *"Hashem builds Jerusalem; gathers the dispersed of Israel; heals the broken-hearted and binds up their sorrows"*

Yeshayahu speaks specifically of bringing good news of salvation to **the humble**: > רוח ה' אלהים עלי... לבשר ענוים לחבוש לנשברי לב

5. Hashem Dwells Among Them

מרום וקדוש אשכון, ואת דכא ושפל רוח להחיות רוח שפלים ולהחיות לב נדכאים

"Though I dwell on high and in holiness, I also dwell with the contrite and humble of spirit — to revive the spirit of the lowly and the heart of the contrite"

The exalted Hashem chooses to dwell precisely with the humble.

6. Humility Is More Valued Than Sacrifices

David's stunning verse:

כי לא תחפוץ זבח ואתנה, עולה לא תרצה. זבחי אלהים רוח נשברה, לב נשבר ונדכה אלהים לא תבזה

"You do not desire sacrifice, that I should give it; You do not want a burnt offering. The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit; a broken and contrite heart, O God, You will not despise."

A humble spirit is the **best korban** — greater than all the burnt offerings.

The Final Verse — Zephaniah

בקשו את ה' כל ענוי הארץ, אשר משפטו פעלו, בקשו צדק, בקשו ענוה. אולי תסתרו ביום אף ה'

"Seek Hashem, all you humble of the earth, who fulfill His justice. Seek righteousness, seek humility. Perhaps you will be sheltered on the day of Hashem's anger."

Three Inferences from This Verse

1. **The seekers of Hashem are primarily the humble** — *"Seek Hashem, all you humble of the earth"*
2. **The humble are the ones who fulfill the mitzvot** — *"who fulfill His justice"*
3. **Seek both righteousness AND humility specifically** — even when you are already humble, the work continues. Humility is a constant journey.

אף שכבר תארם קודם ענוי הארץ, ציווה עליהם להתמיד בדרך הענווה הזאת ולבקש להוסיף בשבחה ולא להסתפק במה שכבר השיג ממנה

Even after being called "humble of the earth," they are still commanded to *seek* humility further. There is no arriving — only deeper seeking.

This is the perfect closing principle: humility is never a destination. The moment you think you've arrived, you haven't.

Closing Words

והוא יתעלה יעזור למי שחפץ ללכת בדרך הענווה הזאת ויעלהו ממדרגה למדרגה עליו... ידרך ענוים במשפט וילמד ענוים דרכו

Hashem will help one who wishes to walk this path of humility and elevate him from level to level. He guides the humble in justice and teaches the humble His way.

Summary of the Entire Chapter (Perek Zayin Complete)

What Humility Is

- Recognition of one's true status without exaggeration
- Internal and external
- Before Hashem and before people
- **NEVER self-debasement**

Three Methods of Training

1. **Practical** — company, possessions, conduct
2. **Through Torah** — stories + 12+ mitzvot
3. **Intellectual** — philosophical analysis of each domain

The Limits and Subtleties

- **Anavah ≠ shiflut** — simple clothes yes, filthy clothes no
- **Honor those who deserve it** (parents, rabbis, those who helped) — don't kiss every ignorant person's hand
- **Leaders suspend external humility** for the sake of the role — but never lose internal humility
- The higher the position, the greater the risk, the more intensive the anti-arrogance regimen

Specific Practices for Most People

- Greet first; respond fully
- Don't seek prominent seats
- Tolerate difficult people without retaliation
- Wear clean simple clothes; keep a clean simple home

The Rewards

- Hashgachah
- Emotional stability
- Prayers heard
- First to see salvation
- Hashem dwells among them
- More valued than sacrifices
- The path of constant growth — never a destination

Coming Up Next

- **After Shavuot:** We begin **Chapter 8 — Bitachon (Trust in Hashem)**
- The longest chapter in HaMaspik
- We will work toward defining what genuine bitachon is, what it requires, and how it relates to other virtues
- A critically important chapter

B'Ezrat Hashem

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/IcEB9-MapEY · More shiurim: rabbikada.com